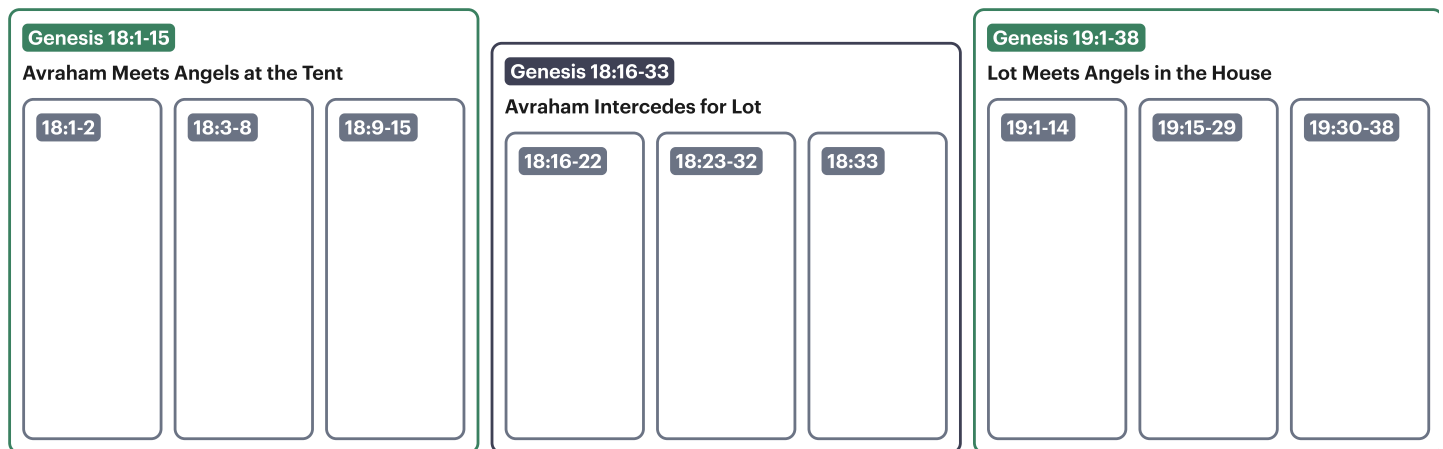


Session 16: Abraham, Sarah, and Yahweh at the Tent

Key Takeaways

- Avraham's meal with God and the two men puts a redemptive twist on the seeing, taking, and eating of Genesis 3.
- Sarah's womb is compared to Eden, which expands a growing network of related images—including the ark, the garden, and the tent—and points to God making new life possible where it seems impossible.

Macro Design of Genesis 18-19



Genesis 18:1-19:38. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The drama between Avraham and Lot began in [Genesis 11:27-12:5](#), when Avraham disregarded God's command to leave his family and brought Lot with him. His choice resulted in the conflict between Avraham and Lot's shepherds ([Gen. 13:5-11](#)), and in the capture of Lot by the Babylonian alliance ([Gen. 14:1-24](#)). That tension culminates in this series of stories.

The symmetrical design invites the reader to make a number of comparisons and contrasts.

- Avraham and Lot's matching receptions of the divine messengers ([Gen. 18:1-8](#) and [Gen. 19:1-14](#)).
- The pregnancy of Sarah and Avraham giving birth to the chosen seed // The pregnancy of Lot's daughters giving birth to the non-chosen seed
- Sarah's unbelief at God's promise // Lot's in-laws' unbelief at his warning

In addition to this large scale bundling of the literary units in [Genesis 18-19](#), the entire sequence has been composed as a large scale symmetry. This design invites the reader to compare and contrast the various parts.

These four larger sections consist of 13 scenes that have been arranged as a large symmetrical chiasm.

Genesis 18:1-15

A - The Future of Abraham's Seed

- **Gen. 18:1** "And he was dwelling (ישב) at the entrance of the tent"
- **Gen. 18:11** "Abraham and Sarah were old (זקן) ... and the way according to women had ceased for Sarah"
- Setting: From under a tree to inside the tent

Genesis 18:16

Part B

- "And the men arose and looked over on the face of Sodom (וישקפו על פני סדם), and Abraham went with them ..."
- Setting: Overlooking Sodom

Genesis 18:17-21

C - Divine Reflections on Abraham's Role in the Fate of Sodom

- "Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do ...?"
- Setting: Not marked

Genesis 18:22-33

D - Abraham Intercedes on Behalf of the Righteous in Sodom and Gomorrah

- **Gen. 18:30, 32** "No please, Lord!" (אל נא) / **Gen. 18:31** "Behold, please!" (הנה נא)
- **Gen. 18:24** "Will you sweep away (ספה), and not forgive (lit. "lift up" נשא)?"
- **Gen. 18:26** "I will forgive" (נשא)
- Setting: Overlooking Sodom

Genesis 19:1-3

E - The Angels (המלאכים) Arrive in Sodom

- **Gen. 19:1** Setting: In the gate of Sodom in the evening

Genesis 19:4-11

F - Lot is Rejected by the Men of Sodom as They Assault the Angels

- **Gen. 19:6-7, 9** "And Lot went out (ויצא) to them ... and spoke (ויאמר) ... and they said, 'Has this immigrant come to assert his judgment?!'"
- Setting: Outside Lot's house

Genesis 19:12-13

G - The Men Announce the Destruction of Sodom

- **Gen. 19:13** “We are about to destroy (שחת) this place for its outcry is great”
- Setting: Inside Lot’s house

Genesis 19:14

F' - Lot Is Rejected by His In-Laws From Sodom

- **Gen. 19:14** “And Lot went out (ויצא) and spoke (וידבר) to his in-laws ... but in their eyes he was playing”
- Setting: Outside Lot’s house

Genesis 19:15-16

E' - The Angels (המלאכים) Force Lot To Leave Sodom

- **Gen 19:16** Setting: Through the gate of Sodom in the morning light

Genesis 19:17-22

D' - Lot Selfishly Pleads That Zoar Be Spared

- **Gen. 19:18** “No please, Lord!” (אל נא) / **Gen. 19:19, 20** “Behold please” (הנה נא)
- **Gen. 19:17** “Escape, lest you be swept away (ספה)” + **Gen. 19:21** “I have lifted up (נשא) your face”
- Setting: Outside the gates of Sodom

Genesis 19:23-26

C' - Divine Judgment on Sodom

- “Yahweh overthrew these cities and all the valley ...”
- Setting: Not marked

Genesis 19:27-29

Part B'

- “And Abraham woke early to the place where he had stood ... and he looked over on the face of Sodom (וישקף על פני סדם) ... and he saw the pillar of smoke.”
- Setting: Overlooking Sodom

Genesis 19:30-38

A' - The Future of Lot’s seed

- **Gen. 19:30** “And he dwelt (ישב) in a cave”
- **Gen. 19:31** “Our father is old (זקן), and there’s no man to come to us like the way of the land”

- Setting: From Zoar to inside a cave

Genesis 18:1-19:38 (Wenham). Genesis 18:1-19:38 (Wenham). Adapted from Wenham, Gordon (2015). [Genesis 16-50, Volume 2 \(Word Biblical Commentary\)](#). Zondervan Academic.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 18:1-15

A ¹ And Yahweh became **seen (ראה)** to him among **the oaks of Mamre**,
and he was dwelling at **the door of the tent** at the heat of the day,
a ² and he lifted his eyes and he **saw (ראה)**,
B b and look, **three men standing by him**,
a' and **he saw (ראה)**
A and **he ran** from **the door of the tent** to meet them,
and he bowed to the ground.

³ And he said,
"My master, please, if I have found favor in your eyes,
a please don't **pass on (עבר)** from **your servant**.
b ⁴ Let him please **take a little water**,
c **so you can wash your feet**,
d and **recline under the tree**;
b' ⁵ that I may **take a bit of bread**,
c' **so you can sustain your hearts**.
a' Then you can **pass on (עבר)**,
for this reason you have **passed by (עבר)** your servant!"

And they said,
"So do as you have spoken."

⁶ And Avraham **hurried** **into the tent** to Sarah,
and he said,
"**Hurry!** Three measures of wheat flour!
Knead it and make cakes!"
⁷ Then Avraham **ran** to the cattle,
and he took **a calf**, good and tender,
and he gave it to the young man,
and **he hurried** **to make it**.
⁸ **And he took** curds and milk and **the calf he made**,
and he gave it before them.
Now, **he was standing by them under the tree**,

and they ate.

⁹ And they said to him,
“Where is **Sarah**, your wife?”

And he said,

A “Look, **in the tent**!”

¹⁰ And he said,

“**I will surely return to you at the time of life
and look, a son for Sarah your wife!**”

a Now, Sarah was hearing this **at the door of the tent**, and it was behind him.

b' ¹¹ Now, Avraham and Sarah were **old**,
going on in years.

B a' There had stopped for Sarah the way of women,
¹² and Sarah **laughed** within herself, saying,
“After I have become **worn out**,
will I have Eden (= ‘delight’),
and my master, being **old**?”

¹³ And Yahweh said to Avraham,
A “What is this, that Sarah **laughed**, saying,
‘Will I really, actually, **give birth**,
even as I am **old**?!’

B ¹⁴ Is anything too wondrous for Yahweh?

A' **At the appointed time I will return to you, at the time of life,
and for Sarah, there will be a son.”**

A'

¹⁵ And Sarah acted with deceit, saying,
a “I did not **laugh**!”
b because she was afraid.

a' And he said,
“No. You really did **laugh**.”

Genesis 18:1-15. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avraham, Sarah, and the Eden Tent

After the flood of judgment and the covenant mercy on Avraham in Genesis 17, we expect the story to return to the thematic melody of the garden, and that is precisely what happens. The story of Avraham welcoming the angelic messengers is portrayed as a reversal of Adam’s folly while, in contrast to her husband, Sarah replays Eve’s failure.

Genesis 18:1, 8 Instructor’s Translation

¹ Yahweh became seen to him **at the oaks of Mamre** ... and he was dwelling **at the door** of the **tent** (האהל).
⁸ ... And Avraham was standing by [the angels] **under the tree**.

- The woman and man commit their folly in the presence of a spiritual being, **at the tree** in the center of Eden. (Gen. 3:1-7)
- Cain murders his brother after giving his offering **at the door of Eden**. (Gen. 4:7-9)
- Noah consumes the fruit of his Eden-like garden, and becomes naked **inside his tent**. (Gen. 9:20-21)

Avraham is among the “oaks of Mamre” where he camped in Genesis 13:18, which evokes the “oak of vision/Moreh” from Genesis 12:7. At these oak trees, Avraham had visions of God’s covenant blessing appearing to him.

Note the pairing of “under the tree” (תחת העץ, Gen. 18:4, 8) and “the door of the tent” (פתח האהל, Gen. 18:1, 2, 10). The tree and the door are both Eden images (door in Gen. 4:7-8) replayed in the ark as well. A man and woman meet with God under a tree and at the door of a tent, and they talk about a fruitful womb. This is all Eden imagery!

Avraham’s Generosity, Sarah’s Folly

In Genesis 16, both Avraham and Sarah acted foolishly, harming Hagar and doing what was good in their eyes. In this story, Avraham reverses course and acts as a generous host to the angelic figures. Sarah, on the other hand, replays her own foolish failure from chapter 16, and she also mirrors the failure of Eve in Genesis 3.

Genesis 18	Genesis 2-3
Gen. 18:1 “Yahweh became seen to him at the oaks of Mamre, and he was dwelling at the entrance of the tent (האהל)”	Gen. 2:9 “Out of the ground Yahweh Elohim caused to grow every tree that is desirable to see, and good for eating; the tree of life also in the middle of the garden , and the tree of knowing good and bad.”
Gen. 18:2 “And Avraham saw (וירא) ...”	Gen. 3:6 “And the woman saw (ותרא) ...”
Avraham’s Generosity, Sarai’s Folly. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Genesis 18	Genesis 2-3
Gen. 18:4 “Be refreshed under the tree (תחת העץ) ”	Gen. 3:6 “... that the tree was good ” (טוב העץ)
Gen. 18:7-8 “And [Avraham] took (ויקח) a son of a cow, tender and good (רך וטוב) and he gave (ויתן) to them ... under the tree (תחת העץ), and they ate (ויאכלו)”	Gen. 3:6-7 “And the woman took (ותקח) from the fruit [of the tree of knowing good and bad ((טוב ורע)] and she ate (ותאכל) and she gave (ותתן) to her husband and he ate (ויאכל)”
Gen. 18:9: “Where (איה) is Sarah your wife?” + “She’s in the midst of the tent (באהל)”	Gen. 3:9: “And Yahweh called to the human, ‘Where are you (איכה)?’”
Gen. 18:10-12 “And Sarah was listening (שמע) behind the entrance of the tent ... and she laughed, saying, ‘After I’m worn out, shall I have Eden (עדנה)?’”	Gen. 3:10 “I heard (שמע) your voice in the garden (גן) [of Eden (עדן)].”
Gen. 18:13 “And Yahweh said, ‘Why this (למה זה) did Sarah laugh?’”	Gen. 3:13 “What is this (מה זאת) you have done?”
Gen. 18:15 “But Sarah lied (כחש), saying ‘I did not laugh.’ Because she was afraid (ירא).”	Gen. 3:10 “I heard (שמע) your voice in the garden, and I was afraid (ירא), so I hid.” Gen. 3:1-2: The snake (נחש) lies to the woman.
<i>Avraham’s Generosity, Sarai’s Folly. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Avraham runs out to meet Yahweh, who appears in the form of three humans, and he persuades them to eat with him under the tree. The food under the tree, however, is a reversal of the forbidden food of the tree in Eden. He is generous and shares what he has with the very person who gave it all to him, his God!

Instead of God providing food for the humans, in this story the man and woman provide food for Yahweh and two angels. This explains the allusions to the priestly preparation of offerings in the food-prep scene in [Genesis 18:6-8](#) (see [Lev. 2:1-7](#)) and the emphasis on “the entrance of the tent” where the sacrifices were offered in the priestly ordination ([Exod. 28-29](#)).

Exodus 29:32-33 NIV

³² At the entrance to the tent of meeting, Aaron and his sons are to eat the meat of the ram and the bread that is in the basket. ³³ They are to eat these offerings by which atonement was made for their ordination and consecration. But no one else may eat them, because they are sacred.

Leviticus 2:1-2 NASB*

¹ Now when anyone presents a grain offering as an offering to the LORD, his offering shall be of **fine flour**, and he shall pour **oil** on it and put frankincense on it. ² He shall then bring it to Aaron's sons the priests [**at the entrance of the tent of meeting**, see Lev. 1:3]; and shall take from it his handful of its fine flour and of its oil with all of its frankincense. And the priest shall offer it up in smoke as its memorial portion on the altar, an offering by fire of a soothing aroma to the LORD.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Instead of the humans taking the forbidden food in Genesis 3, here the humans take of the food that God has already provided and they offer it as a gift to God.

Notice how all of the images of fruitfulness are coordinated here.

- Tent, flock, food, spring, life (עת חיה), and womb
- The actual word "Eden" is used of Sarah's womb in 18:12, which activates the entire Eden complex that covers all these images

Reflection Question

How is Avraham's meal with God and the two men a redemption of the Genesis 3 garden melody?